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WEST COAST EDITION

Keeper lost as storm batters Harrow Ness

From our West Coast correspondent

Fears are being treated as confirmed for Malcolm Teague, 42, principal keeper of the light at Harrow Ness, presumed drowned during the violent storm that struck the west coast on the night of 14 November.

Harrow Ness is among the most isolated manned lights remaining in the Northern Lighthouse network, a bare rock some forty miles out from the mainland with no other inhabitants and no safe anchorage in poor weather. Supply vessels call perhaps once every six weeks, weather permitting, and in winter months keepers can go far longer without any visit at all, relying on radio for their only contact with the mainland.

Mr Teague failed to make his scheduled radio contact shortly after 11pm, prompting concern from operators monitoring conditions, which by then had reached storm force 10 in the area. A relief vessel that reached the station the following morning, after being held back a full day by the weather, found the light extinguished and Mr

Teague absent. No trace of him has since been found despite a search by HM Coastguard and local fishing boats, hampered throughout by the island's distance from the mainland and called off after four days.

A Lantern Commission spokesman said Mr Teague was an exceptionally dedicated and experienced keeper, who had served at Harrow Ness for over a decade and understood its dangers better than most. It is believed he went outside during the storm to attend to damage affecting the light's mechanism.

He would not have left that light dark while there was anything he could do about it, said a colleague.

Mr Teague is survived by his wife, Margaret, and three daughters. A formal determination of death is expected once the Procurator Fiscal's inquiries conclude.